

Left or right?

The wrinkly outer part of your brain is divided into two halves. The left half controls the right side of your body, and the right half controls your left side. For most tasks, one side of your brain is dominant, making you right- or left-handed, right- or left-footed, and even right- or left-eyed and eared.

DIFFERENT SIDES

In addition to controlling different sides of the body, the two sides of the brain specialize in different mental tasks. In most people, for instance, the left side of the brain processes the meaning of words. However, if one side of the brain gets damaged, the other side can sometimes learn to do its job.

WOW!

Enjoying music is strongly linked to the right brain, but creating music that other people enjoy uses the skills of the left brain.

WHICH HAND?

If you're right-handed, the part of your left brain that controls your right hand is dominant over the corresponding part of your right brain. About 90 percent of people are right-handed and 10 percent are left-handed, including President Barack Obama and former presidents Bill Clinton and George H.W.

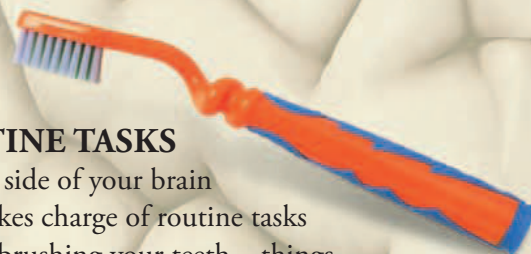
Bush. A few people are ambidextrous: they can use both hands equally well.

Left brain



USING WORDS

Being able to use words fluently is a skill controlled by the left brain. This includes both talking and writing, since both involve using words.



ROUTINE TASKS

The left side of your brain often takes charge of routine tasks such as brushing your teeth—things that you do every day without thinking.



THINKING LOGICALLY

The left brain is usually better than the right brain at dealing with numbers and thinking logically. It gives you the ability to analyze a problem and work out an exact answer, rather than make a guess.

